

TITANOMACHIA
NOVELETTE

MACHINATIONS OF FATE



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KLIMENT DUKOVSKI

MACHINATIONS OF FATE

A TITANOMACHIA NOVELETTE

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MACHINATIONS OF FATE

Captain Talia Daggett sat in the job bureau on the System Command space station, wondering whether to punch the woman across the desk or strangle her and end everyone's misery.

"I don't have anything available for you right now, Ms. Daggett. I am sorry," the woman said in a flat voice, pushing her VR set above her forehead.

No, you're not, Talia thought.

"Look again."

"I already did. Three times." The woman seemed to suppress a yawn.

"That job board listed one hundred open roles for cargo delivery and escort when we entered the system. My ship is more than capable of taking any of them."

"Take them then."

Talia stared at the woman, copying her bored expression. "It requires a Hyperion Industries permit issued inside this space station by an official job officer. You. In person." Talia glanced at the woman's name tag and added, "Pearl."

Pearl raised an eyebrow as if she didn't know this.

"Give me a job. Or a permit, and I'll take a job myself. That's all I'm asking, Pearl."

"Mhm." Pearl pulled her VR set back down over her eyes.

When she didn't say a word after five minutes of staring at her virtual screens, Talia started tapping her foot on the floor. Pearl shot her an annoyed look as her VR shell across her eyes became transparent.

"It says we can't issue new permits here."

"Bullshit."

Pearl pushed her VR set up above her forehead. "We are done here, Ms. Daggett. Next!"

Talia leaned forward and lowered her voice. "I saw your cargo hold when I walked by. You're full. And I don't see as many freighters coming to pick anything up. What I did see was dozens of

ships unloading as we speak, and they're probably halted now because there's no space for the extra cargo. I saw a dozen more freighters crammed with containers on their way to the station. I'm headed back to the Inner Systems anyway. Just give me a permit so I can take a job myself and help everyone at the same time. How about that?"

Pearl stared with dull eyes, not a word coming out of her mouth. "I can't issue a new permit."

"Why?"

"I can't tell you that, Ms. Daggett."

Talia leaned back and crossed her arms. "Because my parents supported the rebels during the War?"

Pearl didn't say anything. She just stared, bored, annoyed, sleepy even.

"This is not the same ship," Talia said. "This is the *Wings of Athena*. My parents flew the *Owl of Athena*. My company is a sole proprietorship of Talia Daggett, founded last year. My parents' company was a partnership..." Talia's words trailed off as she wondered whether she should keep explaining it all to this bureaucrat when perhaps that wasn't the reason for not getting any jobs.

"It's the same ship."

So it was the reason!

"It's not! I fully renovated it and changed half the modules. If anything, it's more of a warship now than a freighter, but we can still haul considerable tonnage."

"Maybe you should try getting a job with the Dragon Armada then."

"It's just a security escort ship, not a battleship!" Talia realized she'd shouted against her will. She stopped, closed her eyes, and took a deep breath. When she opened them again, Talia whispered. "Look, Pearl. Your gate stations are ripping me off every time I pass through Hyperion Industries systems. My fuel is running low, and I'm already late on my loan payments. My ship can take on any job on your board. I would really appreciate it if you gave me a damned permit, and I'll be on my way."

Pearl looked at Talia. Her eyes remained as dull as ever, but for a moment Talia thought she saw a hint of humanity in the bureaucrat. Pearl lowered her VR set back over her eyes.

She's going to give me a permit.

Without facing Talia, Pearl said, "Thank you for considering a role with Hyperion Industries. Next!"

Talia clenched her jaw, thinking now could be the right time to shoot someone if she had a weapon.

A stern voice behind Talia said, "This way, Ms. Daggett."

Talia glanced over her shoulder. A man, fully clad in azure-blue power armor of the Trident private security force, stood waiting.

Talia said to Pearl, "You've called security to throw me out?"

"*Escort* you, Ms. Daggett. I thought you knew what that word meant."

Talia stood up. She never wanted to punch someone so badly. Instead, she clenched her teeth and stomped out of the job bureau office.

* * *

The Trident Security officer escorted her to the docking station, where the cargo hold and hangar bay branched off to the sides, with her ship docked straight ahead in the tunnel.

"Stay out of trouble," the officer said, then left her standing at the intersection, alone. The officer's voice came from a distance. "Get back, you wirehead. You shouldn't be here."

Talia glanced over her shoulder and watched the officer shove a bot aside. The bot limped away, its head lowered. Why it limped, Talia had no idea. She shrugged and focused on her problems, wondering where to go next. Part of her crew was undoubtedly somewhere inside the bars, drinking more than they could handle. Maybe she should do that too and let fate carry her forward.

But we're running out of credits. The thought alone could keep her sober even if she drank the whole bar.

"I need to find work," Talia mumbled, thinking she could ask around for *unofficial* work. A glance at the cargo hold, the chaotic

rush of workers and mechanical mules hauling crates, told her there was certainly work to be found. Talia even started considering smuggling contraband when her medallion rang. Her hand went to the pendant, and she touched the metal owl engraving.

The voice of her comms officer, Cornelia Payne, echoed in her ears. "Captain, I have bad news."

Me too, Talia almost said. We'll be homeless soon.

"What is it?" she asked instead.

"*Iron Redback*, a Vanguard-class destroyer sailing under Arach Prime Lending Company, is approaching our position fast. ETA, twenty minutes."

That wasn't good. "Maybe they aren't here for us."

"Not sure about that, Captain. Its targeting sensors are locked on our ship. Their captain sent a direct message for you."

"Send it to my mail." With that, the comms officer disconnected, and the message appeared on Talia's personal computer.

Talia wondered for a moment whether to play the message. She glanced at the hangar to the side. Some shuttles were landed there. She could get her sister to sneak into one of them, and then Talia could take on the *Redback* if need be. Then she shook her head. *What am I thinking?* She opened the message.

A female face with large, round eyewear appeared, making her look like an insect. Her lips were black, her face pale like a mime's, and her hair was held high with metal wires like antennae. She smiled. "This is Captain Atraxia of the *Iron Redback*. I've been sent by CEO Arach himself to track you down. To be honest, I never imagined you would be scrounging around Hyperion Industries' systems. How pathetic."

"Tell me about it," Talia mumbled.

The message continued. "Anyway, you're two payments behind on your loan. Your agreement with Arach says one late payment, and he repossesses your ship." Captain Atraxia glanced to the side before looking back at the camera. "How you convinced him to extend that to two, I don't know. But here we are. I'm arriving at System Command within twenty minutes. Make sure *Athena's* clean and ready for takeover." The message ended.

Talia tapped her medallion and spoke. "How did we not detect the ship sooner?"

Cornelia Payne's voice spoke in Talia's ears. "It seems the ship uses advanced cloaking systems, Captain. It didn't appear on our sensors until half an hour ago, and even then, its signature wasn't clear. Nicky thought it was a sensor glitch and that the ship was a freighter until it was too late."

Talia exhaled, cursing under her breath. "Don't let anyone inside the ship until I come back."

"Understood, Captain."

"What now, Talia?" Talia mumbled to herself. She still had twenty minutes left before the *Redback* docked.

* * *

Talia knew her crew so well that she didn't even bother checking the smaller bars across the station or calling them to find out where they were; they always went straight to the largest bar on any System Command station as soon as the *Wings of Athena* docked. Apparently, they went where most patrons were, especially women who wanted to earn something extra on top of their Hyperion Industries salary.

"Here's the captain!" Pierre Daggett shouted from across the bar, raising a shot glass and emptying it while the others cheered and then did the same. Talia approached the group as the big guy slammed the glass on the table.

His twin brother Pierce filled it with a questionable silver liquid. "One more for the captain," Pierce said, and everyone cheered again, raising their glasses and drinking the thing in one go.

Pierce grunted and wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. He filled all the shot glasses and passed one to Talia.

"I'm good," Talia said, but everyone cheered her on, so she just forced a smile and shoved the liquid down her throat. The drink came back up almost immediately, the taste of metal, sour fruits, and sweet spices overpowering her senses.

Pierce chuckled as he wrapped one thick, muscled arm around the captain. "Ain't that bad, Captain, am I right?"

Talia nodded, trying to swallow the thing back and keep it down.

"Another?" Pierce asked the captain, and everyone cheered again.

Trying to hold back a grimace, Talia brought her hand to her chest, palm out. "I'm good."

"Oh, come on, Captain," Pierce said.

"You're paying for it, anyway," Pierre added, and everyone laughed and cheered.

"Oh, hell, I am," Talia said and slipped away, letting her crew have the fun they needed. It could very well be their last time together unless she could somehow salvage the situation.

She stopped at the bar instead, casting a quick glance at the patrons around. Katy Daggett, her chief medical officer and cousin, was already flirting with someone who looked like a merc. She smiled at the captain and raised her glass toward her. Talia returned the smile before proceeding to see the others, but none of them seemed of any particular interest.

At the far end, a bot stood with its face screen turned toward Talia for some reason, as if watching her. Its face screen showed sad, pixelated eyes and a mouth slightly curved to one side, almost as if smirking.

Wait, isn't that the same bot that the Trident officer pushed at the dock?

"That's Lucky Bob," the female bartender said as she approached Talia. "It's the lucky charm of this station. Boarded four months ago. No one knows how or why. One day it was just there, standing at the bar, observing patrons. Some say it chooses one."

"Chooses for what?"

"For a turn in fortune."

"Huh. How does that work? Do I wave at the bot or what?" Talia almost smiled at that.

"No one really knows. It just happens, out of nowhere."

That's a pity.

"Tridents hate him for some reason, though." The bartender lowered her voice. "I heard one of them say this was a warrior bot fighting for the rebels during the War."

"That so?" Talia stared at the bot now. It had a weird chassis, wider than a typical bot, rusted around the edges, with some moss on the top of its head. It even moved awkwardly, as if it were damaged. A battlefield injury, perhaps.

"Can I get you something?"

Talia looked back at the bartender. She was a teenage girl, with short, colored hair and a warm smile. Kind of reminded her of Talia's sister, Nicky.

"Information. Got anything worth sharing? Besides Lucky Bob's story."

The bartender smiled. "Depends. What you're looking for?"

"A job."

"A bar is an odd place for a ship captain looking for a job, don't you think? Unless you're looking to join me on this side."

I may be closer to that than you think, little girl.

"I got a warship that can haul cargo. Perhaps a VIP delivery or ship escort, that sort of thing."

"You should try the job bureau two decks above."

"Already did. They wouldn't give me anything. My ship's blacklisted."

The girl raised an eyebrow. "What did you do?"

Talia wondered whether to explain, then decided to anyway. "My parents were on the wrong side during the War."

The bartender didn't say anything. She just nodded, thoughtful.

"I'm open to everything," Talia said. "Doesn't have to be official work. I can be very discreet. I got state-of-the-art weaponry on my ship." Talia lowered her voice so she wouldn't be overheard. "I'm willing to sell them to the right buyer." Hell, if that's what it took to get Atraxia off her back, then so be it. "Know anyone who's looking for that?"

The girl took a glass and filled it with what looked like beer. The glass instantly sweated from the cold liquid. "This is a Hyperion Industries station at the edges of colonized space. Only the Helion

Star System is farther than us. Not sure you'll find anything like that over here, ma'am." The girl set the glass in front of Talia. "It's on me."

Talia pursed her lips and nodded. She brought up her personal computer and sent the girl more credits than the beer was worth. "Thank you for your time." She turned to leave.

"My father died during the War," the girl said. "I was five when I saw him last. He said he's doing this for me so I wouldn't have to live in a world run by corporations. Your parents were on the right side. It just so happens they lost."

Talia glanced back over her shoulder and nodded.

* * *

Captain Talia was headed back toward the cargo hold to start asking around for work when she overheard two Trident Security officers talking about the System Overseer and how pissed he was that an escort ship supposed to arrive today was nowhere to be found.

"He straight-up fired his comms officer," said the Trident, walking leisurely in front of Talia.

"What a dick," said the other.

"Yeah. Do that to me, and you get a metal fist through your face."

"Deserved."

"The pilot of that ship is probably getting fired, too."

"Bet."

"What do you think happened?"

"Beats me."

"There's no pirates around the neighboring systems, so it probably wasn't raided. Malfunction, I say. Some of these fuckers failed to repair a part, and now they're stuck in space."

"Plausible."

"Poor bastards losing their jobs for sure."

"For sure."

"Not gonna lie, seeing the Overseer pissed made my day..."

Talia stopped in the corridor, the Trident's words trailing off and mixing with the voices of all the workers in Hyperion Industries coveralls who passed by.

Did she hear that right? The System Overseer needed an escort ship?

Her medallion rang then. Talia tapped the owl engraving, and the voice of Cornelia Payne, her comms officer, talked in her ears. "Captain, there are some people outside the hangar door demanding we open up or they'll blast it open. Looks like that *Iron Redback* captain, Atraxia. She's been calling you for the past five minutes."

"Reroute her calls to my computer from now on. And don't let anyone in. Call SysCom security if they try something stupid."

"You got it, Captain."

Talia turned and went to the information panel. She made a few taps and found the location of the Overseer's office: one deck above her current position, a seven-minute walk through crowded corridors.

Captain Talia was halfway there when Captain Atraxia called her. Talia said, "Atraxia."

There was silence on the other end for about a minute, prompting Talia to check if the call was still connected.

"What games are you playing, Captain Talia? Or should I just call you Talia because you no longer have a ship?"

"Sorry, I've been busy getting work to repay your loan." Talia picked up her pace to a trot.

Atraxia laughed on the other end. "We're past that point now. Tell your crew to open the door. Or we cut it open and throw everyone out. I'm giving you a chance for an honorable retreat—"

Talia hung up.

She was standing ten steps away from the Overseer's office. A massive wooden door and a wooden wall stretched from one end to the other of the corridor. The words Selene Star System Overseer shone brightly above the door. Two security robots stood to the sides, armed with standard-issue pulse rifles. Two Trident Security officers, equally armed and wearing their power armor, flanked the door.

One of the Tridents stepped closer to Talia. With his helmet fully enclosing his head, his voice came out deep and mechanical, like a robot. "This is a restricted area. Move along."

Atraxia called again, and Talia turned off the sound on her personal computer.

"I need to see the Overseer."

"He's not expecting visitors."

"How do you know?"

The Trident's face shield retracted, revealing an annoyed face boasting a thick bronze mustache.

"You wanna get arrested, is that it?" he said, his voice still deep but now human.

"I want to see the Overseer."

"So does every other fucker on this station. Move along."

Talia stepped closer, and the Trident stopped her with a metal palm on her chest. Standing at least two heads taller than Talia in his fully mechanical armored suit, he leaned forward. "One more step and I'll put you in jail. Final warning."

"The escort ship that was supposed to arrive isn't coming. You probably know that, don't you?" Talia stopped to get his reaction, but the fact that he didn't interrupt meant she was probably on the right track. "I'm the replacement. My ship, *Wings of Athena*, is fully armed and ready to take over the task. If you don't let me see the Overseer, I'll file a formal complaint with Hyperion Industries. If that special cargo isn't delivered on time, it'll be on you. And you know how the Overseer gets when he's pissed, firing everyone left and right."

The Trident clenched his jaw. Thoughts flickered across his eyes as they moved over Talia's face and body.

"Wait here."

He turned and walked back to his friend, whispering something. The Trident was back in front of Talia. "Nice try. Take her back to the dock!"

One of the security robots stepped closer and grabbed her by the arm.

"You'll regret this," Talia told the Trident, who seemed annoyed that someone had interrupted the dumb conversation he probably had with his buddy.

"Make sure she boards her ship and leaves the station," the Trident told the robot. "I'll see that her docking permit is revoked."

* * *

Talia and the security robot walked in silence toward the docking bay, while her computer kept ringing.

Annoyed with Atraxia, Talia answered. "What do you want?"

"Oh, hey, Captain. Sorry to bother you." Talia checked the caller's name. Jason Lee, her operations foreman. "I found some very affordable parts I can use to make our drones fully modular. If we could make this acquisition, we could improve all our—"

"Yeah, sure," Talia ended the call, her mind completely on the mess she found herself in. No one wanted to hire her anymore. Corporate job boards were blocked across all systems around Elysium. Maybe she should've equipped her ships for exploration and taken on a UN mission to explore uncharted systems. At least she would've been far from Arach Corp and everyone else.

Too late for that now, is it?

There had to be a way out.

With no solution in sight, Talia reached the docking bay, where Atraxia and her men waited for the *Wings of Athena* hangar bay door to open.

All six of Atraxia's men were fully clad in power armor like the one Tridents wore, except these were black with a red stripe on their backs. None of them wore any weapons because only Hyperion Industries security was allowed to, but a single punch from that metal armor would be enough to kill anyone on impact.

They all turned toward Talia and fell into formation behind Atraxia. Even without weapons, they seemed menacing enough.

"There you are," Atraxia said as she approached Talia, her black lips stretching into a smile. She still wore those big black round eyewear that made her look like a bug. Her hair looked even more

ridiculous in person, with strands woven around wires that rose like antennae. What surprised Talia was that Atraxia wasn't as tall as she'd expected. At least a head shorter than Talia, but slim like a humanoid robot, she stood with the confidence of someone representing Arach Prime Lending.

"I thought you would never come to welcome us to our new ship," Atraxia said.

The security robot let go of Talia and stepped back.

"I told you I was busy securing work for *my* ship."

Atraxia leaned back and laughed dramatically, her mouth wide open, spit flying in all directions. Talia thought for a moment she might choke. Some of Atraxia's men started laughing when she turned toward them.

"I'll pay your two months plus another two months in advance by the end of the day."

Atraxia stopped laughing. On her toes, she leaned her head closer to Talia. Talia couldn't see her eyes beyond the black round eyewear. Instead, Talia watched her own distorted reflection, her head wider than her body, staring back at her. If that's how Atraxia saw everyone, no wonder she laughed.

Atraxia laughed again, louder.

Talia squinted and grimaced as if that would keep that annoying sound from getting into her head.

When Atraxia stopped, Talia said, "I'm happy you had your laugh, Captain Atraxia. But if you don't mind, I have to secure a job."

Talia turned, and a hand grabbed her by the arm, halting her.

"Open the door, Talia. Or this will be an unpleasant encounter for you and your crew."

"I just heard you laugh. How much more unpleasant can you make it?"

"Oh, you'd be surprised."

A series of bursts echoed behind the captain, and dozens of mini spider bots, black with red stripes on their backs, crawled in a coordinated swarm and stopped in front of Talia.

Straight ahead, beyond the spider bots, the security robot that escorted Talia to the dock stood silent, its optical sensors observing

the situation. There was no hint that the bot would prevent Atraxia from hurting Talia.

Talia glanced over her shoulder. "Why don't you visit the bar deep within the station, get a few drinks, and I'll have your credits ready. Tell the girl at the bar that the drinks are on me."

"How about you open the door, and I'll make sure to hire some of your crew to work for me."

"I'm not giving you my ship."

"Then we have a problem."

"No, we don't. Get a few drinks. By the time you're done, you'll have your credits."

"You have ten seconds to open the door, or I'm cutting it open."

"You can't. I'll call security."

Atraxia laughed again.

"Please, stop, you're hurting my ears," Talia said, hands cupping her ears.

Atraxia pulled Talia hard, and she couldn't help but turn to face Atraxia's bug-like face. She was really strong for her size.

"We can do whatever we want. The repossession agreement allows us to take your ship however we see fit. We'll just have to cover the minor inconvenience cost. If you're hoping Hyperion security will stop us, your head is emptier than I thought. Time's up. Bring in the cutter!"

"Wait!" Talia shouted, freeing herself from Atraxia's grasp. "Fine. I'll open the door."

Atraxia grinned. "That wasn't so hard, was it?"

They all turned toward the door and started walking forward. The mini spider bots retreated toward the men in power armor, climbing over their backs and entering what looked like small ports.

Someone shouted from behind, "Watch out! He's got a gun!"

Someone screamed. Others shouted. The security bot turned toward the hangar bay and started forward. While everyone was focused on the chaos, someone grabbed Talia's hand and pulled her away. Talia just went with it, dashing through the crowded corridor, pushing a woman accidentally. "Sorry!"

Talia sprinted as fast as her legs would hold.

A teenage boy, as tall as Talia and wearing a VR headset, was running next to her. "This way!" he said, and they turned into a narrow opening that the boy sealed behind them.

"Who are you?"

"A friend."

"I don't have any friends in Selene."

"Well now you do. Start climbing." Talia wasn't going to argue. It was either that or giving the *Wings of Athena* to Atraxia.

* * *

After a few minutes of climbing a metal ladder through an enclosed space, they reached the second deck. The boy crawled through what looked like a maintenance shaft beneath a corridor. Whoever walked above them stepped over their heads.

The boy stopped near a hatch. "Wait," he said.

Talia wiped sweat from her forehead. The heat inside the maintenance shaft was unbearable.

"Come." The boy opened the hatch, and Talia followed him into a room. He closed the door and locked it manually so no one could open it from outside.

Talia looked around the dim-lit room. Drawers built into the walls were the only items inside, and there was nothing to sit on. If she stretched her arms, she could touch two walls facing each other. Warning signs said that beds open from the walls when needed.

"Okay, *friend*," Talia said. "You got some explaining to do."

The boy started opening drawers, searching for something. In a squeaky voice, he said, "The girl you met at the bar; The bartender. She's my friend. She told me you were blacklisted because you were friends with the rebels during the War."

"What? No, no, no. You got it all wrong."

The boy grabbed something like a folded blanket and shoved it into Talia's hands. "Do not sell your ship's weapons. We'll need them for the next war."

"There won't be a next war. What are you talking about?"

"Take it." The boy shoved the blanket into Talia's hands again, and she took it involuntarily. "Put it over. It'll make you inconspicuous to the security cameras and bots. Go on. We have another ten minutes before they find us here."

"Look, I'm here looking for a job, not trouble."

"Well, at least you found one of the two." The boy chuckled. That wasn't funny. "You know what'll happen when they find me? They'll ban me from Hyperion Industries space forever."

"Is that a bad thing? They won't give you a job anyway."

Fair point. "I still need permission to traverse their space."

The boy had already put on his cloak, his VR set the only thing visible on his face. "Put it on."

Talia obliged. She put the thing on and pulled a hood over her hair. "And this will keep security from spotting me?"

"Yes."

"I look like a hobo."

"I heard you'll become one if you don't get a job soon."

"Ha-ha. I never mentioned that to your girl. How do you know?"

The boy just smiled and grabbed Talia's hand, pulling her toward the door. He unlocked it, peeked while wearing his VR, and when he was sure no one was there, they slipped out of the room into what seemed like an oddly empty corridor.

"What's with the VR?"

The boy turned toward Talia. "I get special clues."

"For what?"

The boy didn't answer. He stopped near an intersection and peeked to the side. "This way."

"Where is everyone?" Talia asked, amazed that the corridors were completely empty.

"Everyone works sixteen hours a day to make ends meet. They live here, six people crammed in one room like canned fish. But no one's here now. They're working. When we overthrow Hyperion, we'll live free."

This kid is insane.

"You'll still have to work, even without corps telling you what to do. You know that, right?"

"Everyone will work on whatever they want and be happy. How did humans live before some greedy dude decided it was a good idea to create a corporation? Everyone was happy back then."

"You don't know that."

"Oh, I do. Trust me."

"Historians would probably disagree."

The boy stopped in the corridor just as it was starting to get crowded. He turned toward Talia, his voice cracking. "What historians? History is written by the victors. Don't believe everything you read, Captain. Someone put those fake stories there for a reason. They *need* us to be docile, to follow the rules, to make execs rich. Don't be fooled. Stories were created for that."

Talia didn't plan to argue. She had more pressing things to worry about.

As they walked through the corridor, her computer rang. Talia answered without looking at the caller. "What is it?"

"Captain," the voice of drunk Pierre came through, slurring his words. "Security's rounding us up. Can I punch 'em?" His twin brother Pierce laughed in the background.

"What? What do you mean?" Talia asked.

"Yeah, these Trident bastards are takin' us some're at gunpoint. I can take 'em with my bare hands, I swear."

"I know you can, Pierre. Don't do anything stupid. Do as they say. I got this." To the boy, Talia said, "They are rounding up my crew."

"Shit. I knew that would happen. Don't worry, I have a plan. We will sabotage the station and—"

"Whoa, hold on. Keep your explosives in your pants, boy. We aren't sabotaging anything."

Talia's computer rang again. She answered. "What!"

"Nice stunt you did back there, Talia." The voice of Atraxia slithered through the computer. "But you have crossed the line. A little spider told me Nicky was having fun at the station."

Talia stopped. "What did you say?"

"See, your little sis wants to sneak out of your ship every now and then when you dock. Her and that little pilot boy, Diomedes."

See, my spiders found them hiding in a room. You have ten minutes to come to the dock and unlock my ship. Or I'm taking these two little lovebirds as hostages on my ship. Don't worry, I'll put their skills to good use." Atraxia laughed as she hung up.

Talia quickly picked up her medallion and tapped it. "Where's Nicky?"

Cornelia Payne's voice came loud in the captain's ears. "She was at the bridge until about half an hour ago. She said she didn't feel well and went to her quarters."

Talia disconnected the call, shouting, "Fuck!"

Everyone stopped and looked her way.

"Shhh. What are you doing?" the boy whispered.

"They got my sister."

* * *

Talia was running through the corridor, all bets off. She didn't care about a job; she didn't care about the ship; she would grab Atraxia by the throat and strangle her right there. If that didn't work, she would have her crew unload everything they had on the *Iron Redback*. If that pale bitch wanted war, war she would get.

As the captain dashed through the corridors, slipping between the crowds, she didn't notice someone standing in front of her. She smacked into him with all her momentum, bounced back, and fell to the ground. Talia stood up immediately, mumbling, "Sorry, didn't see you there."

"You... apologized to me?" a gentle mechanical voice said.

That's when Talia noticed it was that robot—what was it... *Lucky Bob*?

"Yes, I—"

"You treat me like a person. Not a machine." Lucky Bob said.

"What? Sorry, I would've apologized even if you were a wall. Didn't see you standing there."

"You treat me kindly."

"Yes, sorry, I have to go."

"They call me Lucky Bob."

I know. "Nice to meet you, Lucky Bob."

"Pleasure is all mine, kind Madam Talia."

Talia was about to continue her run when she stopped. "How do you know my name?"

"Captain Talia is kind to Lucky Bob. Being kind to Lucky Bob brings good fortune."

Ching.

Three reels appeared on Lucky Bob's face screen and started spinning, with electronic whirs following the spin.

First reel stopped. B.

Second reel. O.

Third one. B.

A lucky horseshoe appeared on Lucky Bob's face.

"What the..."

Talia's medallion rang. Talia touched it instinctively, her eyes on the flashing horseshoe and the sparkles exploding around it.

Cornelia Payne spoke. "Captain, you got a priority one message."

"Cornelia, I really don't have time for—"

"It's labeled urgent. Job offer expiring soon."

"What job offer?" Talia turned back toward Lucky Bob, but he wasn't there. Talia opened the message on her computer.

A lone white star on a black background appeared. A voice spoke, "Captain Talia. I have an urgent job offer for you. Three cargo containers delivered to Helion Star System. They await in the Selene System Command station cargo hold. Thank you."

The message disappeared, and a sum of eight figures appeared on her screen if she accepted the job.

"That's more than enough credits to pay Atraxia," Talia mumbled.

Talia called her operations foreman first. "Jason, we got a job! Load three Hyperion-labeled crates right now! I'm forwarding the details."

She called Atraxia next, but the bitch didn't answer. Talia dreaded that something might've happened to Nicky.

The captain was running through the crowds now, noticing that the boy wasn't running next to her. Just as she was about to turn

and look for him, a mechanical voice shouted, "Halt!" and she stopped.

The crowd dispersed, revealing a security bot standing in the middle of the corridor, aiming a rifle at Talia. "Captain Talia Daggett of the *Wings of Athena*."

"Damn right I am. Tell that to Atraxia."

"You are detained. Follow me," the bot said.

"I'm not following you anywhere."

"This is not a request." The bot flipped a switch on its rifle, and it began to buzz with electricity.

Talia glanced around, looking for the boy to tell her where to run. But he was nowhere to be found.

Great job, Talia. You antagonized your only ally.

"That spider bitch has taken my sister hostage. Where do I report that?"

"Report taken and forwarded. Follow me, Captain Talia."

"Or what?"

The bot squeezed the trigger. An electric bolt shot from the rifle. It struck Talia in the chest, penetrating her uniform. Her legs instantly gave out, and she dropped as if someone had swept her feet. Talia slammed her face into the ground, and that was the last thing she remembered.

* * *

Talia found herself sitting somewhere. A large room, dim lighting, a massive wooden desk in the middle. The scent of flowers overpowered her senses.

"Not bad for a prison," Talia said. Then she remembered she'd never been to prison and maybe this was normal. Maybe everyone who complained about prison was lying.

She tasted blood then, licked her dry lips, tasting even more blood. Talia touched her nose, grimaced at the pain, and felt caked blood around her nose and mouth.

"Sorry about that," a male voice said from somewhere.

"About what?" Talia looked around the room. A man wearing a golden shirt beneath a black suit sat across from her, his face shrouded in darkness.

"About the bot shooting you. I had it decommissioned immediately. That machine will never see another day."

"Totally deserved. I guess."

"Refreshment?"

"I'm good."

"I am Brad Leon, the Selene System Overseer."

"Pleasure to meet you."

"Apologies for not getting to you sooner, Captain Talia. By the time I was notified of your presence outside my office, my team wasn't able to find you."

Talia straightened in her chair. "You have a big station, Overseer. It can be easy to get lost."

"Indeed we do." The man paused. "Captain, I'll be blunt. I need your services. There's a VIP on my station who had to be transported to the Helion Star System yesterday. As you know, the escort ship never arrived. I just learned that a catastrophic malfunction had the ship stranded in the middle of nowhere in the Pandia Star System. It will take days to tow it back for repairs, not to mention until it can be fully operational again. Other escort ships will take at least two days to arrive. That leaves me with one option. You, Captain."

Captain Talia couldn't believe what she was hearing.

"I thought I was blacklisted."

"Blacklisted?" A computer screen lit up the Overseer's face as he read something. "I can't find anything of the sort here."

"What?"

Pearl, you bitch.

"I need your ship, Captain. Right now."

"All right. I'm open to offers."

"I don't have time for negotiations, so this is my first and final offer." The man tapped something on his computer and Talia's computer beeped.

The offer had eight figures.

"No way," she mumbled. That was at least twenty times the price of a one-person escort in a neighboring system.

Lucky Bob, I owe you a drink.

"Do we have a deal?"

Does Athena have wings? "There's one thing."

"Listening."

"There's a misunderstanding between the captain of the *Iron Redback* and me. I want her off my back."

"What exactly do you need, Captain?"

"My sister is being held hostage somewhere on this station by the captain's crew. I need her free. Plus I need a guarantee of safe passage to the Helion Star System gate and back through the Selene Star System on our way out."

"We can probably arrange that."

"Thank you, Mr. Overseer." Talia stood up on wobbly legs, reaching for the chair to steady herself.

"Are you okay, Captain?"

She still felt a bit dizzy from the fall. "Takes a little more than an electric shock to hurt me, Overseer."

"I can have my Tridents escort you to your ship, if you'd like."

Talia had had enough of any security escort.

But on second thought... "I would appreciate that, Mr. Overseer." Talia stopped at the door, turned toward the man across the desk. "I'll ensure your VIP has the most pleasant trip to the Helion System Command station."

"That's all I need. Farewell, Captain Talia."

* * *

When Talia approached her ship's docking bay, Atraxia grinned at first, then turned angry when she saw a group of ten fully armed Trident Security officers escorting Talia to the ship.

"What are you doing?" Atraxia asked, eyes darting between Talia and the Tridents.

Talia brought up her computer and sent four months of payments to Atraxia's computer.

"There," Talia said. "Two months I owed and two months up front."

"This is not our agreement, Talia—"

"It's *Captain* Talia. If you'd excuse me, I have a job to do."

The ship's siren blared, and the hangar door opened downward into a ramp. Some of Talia's officers were already at the ramp inside the ship, clad in power armor, pulse rifles in hand, ready to defend the ship at the captain's command.

Captain Atraxia stepped in front of Talia, blocking her path. "This is a direct breach of the Arach Lending contract."

"No, it's not. You got your payment."

Atraxia bristled and growled. Eight metal limbs extended from her back like a spider, all eight sharp blades touching Captain Talia's face and body, but not a scratch on her.

The Tridents and Talia's armed crew instantly raised their rifles toward Atraxia and her crew.

"Can I punch 'em, Cap?" Pierre wobbled from behind, fists ready for a fight, his breath smelling just as dangerous.

Talia simply smiled at Atraxia, who was obviously fuming, trembling with anger, teeth bared. Then Atraxia's grimace changed in an instant. She smiled at Talia. "Don't scratch my ship. I'll be taking it one way or another."

"Sure you will."

Atraxia retracted her metal limbs and stomped out of the docking bay toward her ship, her crew following closely behind.

Diomedes, Talia's pilot, passed by, offering an awkward smile to his captain as Nicky walked behind him. She approached Talia, who embraced her tightly. "Nicky!"

"What did I miss?" Nicky asked but didn't return the embrace.

Talia let go and cupped her sister's face. "Are you hurt?"

"I'm not hurt. What are you talking about?"

Nicky doesn't know she was held hostage.

"Nothing," Talia said. "I was just worried about you, that's all."

"Can't I take a break from duty and get a drink once in a while?"

Talia cleared her throat. "Of course, you can. Proceed to the ship, Officer Daggett. We're going to the Helion Star System."

Katy arrived next, holding a man's hand. His friend followed behind them. Both carried heavy metal containers on wheels, taller than they were, each carrying their personal power armor frames.

"I met these two cute gentlemen at the bar," Katy told the captain. "They're mercenaries who served in the Tridents and, before that, as personal security. They offered their services for free."

Nothing's for free, Katy. "Should've asked me before asking them aboard."

Katy smiled. "I knew you would approve."

No, I wouldn't. But Talia could probably use the extra firepower somehow. "Welcome aboard."

Both soldiers saluted her and entered the ship.

The operations foreman arrived next, with five long crates of equipment following him. "Thank you, Captain. I'll make sure to put them to good use."

Talia just watched him with a raised eyebrow, not the least bit sure what he was talking about.

"Did you load the container crates?"

"Oh, yes. They are securely tucked into *Athena's* hull."

Talia nodded.

Everyone in the docking corridor parted to let another group of Tridents pass by. They were escorting someone in an elegant black suit, just like the Overseer wore. He walked with confidence and the gait of someone important. Without a word, he entered the ship, a small bag on wheels following him closely.

The Trident officer who escorted the man stopped in front of Talia. It was the same bronze mustache that hadn't let her inside the Overseer's office.

"Leaving the station, huh?" he said. "Good riddance."

"Didn't the Overseer fire you for not letting me into his office?"

The Trident gave an annoyed smile and strode back into the station, his fellow Tridents following in line.

Everyone had already boarded the ship. The captain would leave last, as was the custom.

Talia turned her back on the station and started walking up the ramp when someone shouted from the crowd. "Wait! Don't leave,

wait!”

A slightly overweight woman, making a pathetic attempt to run, with a VR headset pushed up over her forehead, came closer to Talia.

Talia turned. “Pearl,” she said, recognizing the woman from earlier. “I thought you never left the office.”

Pearl was panting hard. “I signed your job permit.” She tapped something on her computer, and Talia’s computer pinged.

“Funny how life works,” Talia said. “All you had to do was give me a permit when I asked you earlier. Would’ve saved you the extra calories you burned on your way here.”

“I don’t know how you removed the blacklist, but I’ll be sure to investigate.”

“It was a turn of fortune, Pearl. I hope it happens to you someday.”

Pearl scoffed as she turned her back on Talia and left the captain standing alone at the ramp.

Somewhere in the crowd, Talia thought she saw Lucky Bob standing, observing the entire scene. Maybe there was something to his story after all.

* * *

In the lower decks of the Selene System Command station, Lucky Bob limped under the guise of darkness. A steady *tap, tap, tap* as his metal feet touched the metal floor, one leg two centimeters shorter than the other. The sound echoed in the empty corridor.

Lucky Bob stopped in front of a door labeled Waste Management. He glanced both ways to make sure no one followed him. Then he entered.

The smell of decaying biological matter hit his nostrils. Heavy machines incinerated what couldn’t be recycled, while recycling the rest into a reusable substance and turning it into a paste for the upper decks.

Behind the incinerator, a teenage boy sat in a chair, leaning back, feet up on a desk, hair drenched in sweat. A VR set hid his eyes. Above the desk, dozens of surveillance screens lit up the otherwise dim room.

"I thought you'd stay at that docking bay, staring at the captain, forever," the boy said to Lucky Bob.

Lucky Bob moved his hands to his head, grabbed the metal on both sides, twisted it sharply to the left, and pulled it up.

"I wanted to ensure she took the crates and left the station," Lucky Bob said, his voice as human as the boy's. He removed the metal glove and wiped some sweat off his forehead with the back of his hand. "Need to fix the climate control inside this damned suit. Or I'll fry and blow my cover."

The boy chuckled. "Endure, Pops. We're almost there," he said, then pushed his VR set up over his forehead to look at Lucky Bob with his eyes. "Great timing with the hack, though. Would've been real tricky if you hadn't removed the blacklist. That spider chick would've probably taken Talia's ship. Weeks of planning down the drain."

"Shit's getting worse every time," Lucky Bob said, then removed other parts of his metal clothing to reveal a half-human, half-cybernetic body. He grabbed a cooling cloak from a hanger, put it on, and took a seat next to the boy. "How did you get her to trust you?"

The boy was grinning. "Told her the bartender girl was a friend. She bought it straight up."

All the surveillance screens went black at that moment. A lone white star appeared in the middle.

"Well done, brothers," a voice said. "My agents disabled the escort ship, and the *Wings of Athena* took its place. With that, the final piece of the puzzle is set. It would not have been possible without your outstanding work."

"Thanks," Lucky Bob said.

"That's really cool, man," the boy said. "But we can't wait forever. When do we start?"

The voice fell silent for a moment, then said, "Now."

"All right," the boy said, straightening in his seat and extending his fist toward Lucky Bob, who returned the fist bump.

Lucky Bob said, "I've been waiting for this day for eleven years, for a chance to get back at the corps for what they did to my family."

The voice said, "The fight for freedom is now in your hands."

"We won't disappoint you, man."

"I know. Good luck."

THE END

CONTINUE THE STORY

Thank you so much for reading! I hope you enjoyed the story. I would love to hear your thoughts. You can leave a review on your favorite store, on [Amazon](#), or on Goodreads.

If you want to know more about Captain Talia Daggett, her story continues in the [Titanomachia series, book one: Mirror Moon](#).

To get extra content like a star system map, the history behind the Titanomachia world, and book promotions visit [Kliment Dukovski's website](#).